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THA 252: Fundamentals of Radio, TV and Film Production

Plan, shoot and edit a short production with the equipment you actually have

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack is a production manual for students with limited equipment: a phone, a borrowed camera and free editing software. It covers formats and durations, scripting for radio and screen, shooting coverage, sound capture, editing workflow and delivery formats.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Write a production proposal with format, audience, duration and budget.
- Record clean sound and shoot usable coverage on limited equipment.
- Edit a short sequence with continuity and a coherent mix.
- Export and deliver in the required broadcast or online format.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Formats and scripts

Different media demand different scripts.

- Radio drama: sound-only storytelling; write for ears, not eyes.
- Radio magazine or news: timing, cue and actuality inserts.
- Television: visual continuity, presenter links and package structure.
- Short film: visual storytelling with economy; fewer locations, stronger scenes.
- Documentary: research, contributor access, ethics and release forms.
- Always write to a duration you can actually fill.

Production on limited equipment

Technique beats gear at student level.

- Lock exposure and focus manually where possible; autofocus hunts in low light.
- Record sound close to the source; a cheap lavalier beats a distant camera mic.
- Shoot coverage: wide, medium, close and cutaways for every scene.
- Observe the 180-degree rule and keep screen direction consistent.
- Use available light thoughtfully; bounce and diffuse before adding fixtures.
- Log every take with scene, shot and notes.

> **Sound first**
> Audiences forgive soft images but not unusable audio. Capture clean dialogue and wild track before you chase a prettier shot.

Post-production and delivery

Editing is where the story is actually built.

- Organise footage by scene and take before editing.
- Assemble a rough cut for story, then refine rhythm.
- Keep audio levels consistent; avoid clipping.
- Add music only where licensed or original.
- Colour-correct for consistency rather than spectacle.
- Export to the required codec, resolution and duration; check playback on a phone.

The production chain, end to end

Every production, from a thirty-second radio ident to a short film, runs the same chain: development, pre-production, production, post-production, distribution. The proportions change but the order does not, and skipping a stage costs more later than it would have cost then.

Pre-production is where the production is actually won. Script locked, locations confirmed with written permission, equipment tested, crew roles assigned, schedule written with travel time, and a shot list or running order prepared. A student crew that arrives without a shot list will shoot what is in front of them and discover in the edit that a reaction shot was never captured.

Post-production is where the material becomes a programme. Logging, assembly, rough cut, sound work, colour, titles and export. Export settings matter: a file that is too large to submit or too compressed to screen has failed the assignment at the last step.

Sound first, because it is hardest to fix